

FABALES

Found all over the world, except for Antarctica, the Fabales have compound leaves with tiny outgrowths (stipules) at the base and seed pods that open when mature. Called legumes, these plants have nodules – swellings that contain bacteria – on their roots that help them fix nitrogen from the air into soil. The Fabaceae, the largest of the four families, includes plants like the pea with flowers that have a large upper petal with adjacent smaller petals.

PEANUT

Arachis hypogaea
F: Fabaceae

Native to Brazil, this legume has yellow, reddish veined pea-like flowers. Its seed pod matures in the ground, producing peanuts.



50 cm
20 in

SEED POD

HERBACEOUS PLANT

pinnate leaf

GOLDEN SHOWER TREE

Cassia fistula
F: Fabaceae

This slender tree from S.E. Asia has pendulous, pea-like flowers and pinnate leaves with three to eight pairs of leaflets. Its seeds are poisonous.

80 cm
32 in

FLOWER RACEME

20 m
65 ft

DECIDUOUS LEAFLET

GLOSSY LEAVES

POD HAS EDIBLE PULP

40 m
130 ft

WEST INDIAN LOCUST TREE

Hymenaea courbaril
F: Fabaceae

This hardwood tree has a straight, thick trunk and stems of white-purplish flowers with large petals and long stamens. Orange gum oozes from its trunk, which is used in incense and perfumes.

flowers are clusters of stamens with reduced petals

SAINFOIN

Onobrychis viciifolia
F: Fabaceae

This fodder crop from S. Europe has green, oval, pinnate leaves with 6–14 pairs of leaflets. Densely packed pink flowers appear on a main stem.

LEAF SPRIG

20 m
65 ft

SEED PODS

SILVER WATTLE

Acacia dealbata
F: Fabaceae

This tree has fragrant flowers and silvery bark, ageing to black. Native to S.E. Australia, silver wattle is often called mimosa elsewhere.

1.2 m
4 ft

60 cm
23½ in

KIDNEY VETCH

Anthyllis vulneraria
F: Fabaceae

A plant of dry, grassy places throughout Europe, this perennial has silky-haired stems and clusters of yellow to red flowers, with a ruff of downy bracts beneath.

TAMARIND

Tamarindus indica
F: Fabaceae

This evergreen tree with drooping branches from East Africa and Asia has yellow-orange flowers on stems and edible pulp inside the seed pod.

12 m/40 ft

FLAT WATTLE

Acacia glaucoptera
F: Fabaceae

The globular flowers of this spreading shrub from S.W. Australia grow from a modified stem looking like a twisted leaf.



50 cm/20 in

SENSITIVE PLANT

Mimosa pudica
F: Fabaceae

This prickly S. American plant's leaves close when touched. Its flowerheads (1 cm/⅜ in) usually have pink flowers and long, pink-purple stamens.